

DESIGNING A WILDERNESS

In designing a wilderness, the DM will go through a number of steps quite similar to those of creating a dungeon. The following section explains the process in detail.

A. DECIDE ON A SETTING.

The DM should decide what the area will be like overall. It may be mountains or steppes, woods or desert. It may be based on a fantasy novel or created entirely by the DM. In any case, the DM should first decide the size of the wilderness area he or she wants to work with. It is suggested that the first area be fairly small, such as a barony, an island, or a valley. Small, confined areas are easier for a beginning DM to control, and they take less time to design.

B. DRAW A MAP OF THE AREA.

The next step is to draw a map of the area. The DM may want to look at an atlas or other real maps for reference, as these will give an idea of how real terrain fits together. Common sense should be used — rivers flow downhill, mountains and islands form in chains, forests seldom border deserts, and jungles will have many rivers and swampy areas. A decision should also be made at this point whether to use regular graph paper or special paper that is gridded into hexagons (hex paper). Graph paper is easier to find, but hex paper makes it easier to figure movement.

The DM will usually want to start with a large scale map that shows only major terrain features, working to a small scale map that shows things in more detail. For example, a large scale map might be 24 miles to the hex (or square), while a small scale map might be 6 miles to the hex (or square). It is a good idea to sketch the terrain in pencil first, so that changes can be made easily.

C. PLACE THE DUNGEON AND THE BASE TOWN.

Up to now, most characters have been adventuring in a dungeon that was assumed to be near a town. Both of these should now be placed on the map. The town is likely to be near a waterway or trade route, while the dungeon is usually in a deserted or desolate area. The dungeon should not be too close to the town (or the town would probably be overrun by the dungeon's monsters) but should not be more than a day's journey away. If the town and dungeon are placed near the center of a small scale map, the players will be able to explore in all directions.

D. LOCATE AREAS UNDER HUMAN CONTROL.

Areas controlled by humans should now be placed, as these will usually be the areas where the characters will start the campaign. The areas should be logically placed; for example, many humans would be found on good farming land near rivers, but few would live in a desert. Thought should also be given to who controls these areas. This may be a high level NPC, a king or baron, a council of rich merchants, and so on. The DM may want to do some reading on historical countries in order to design "real" human cultures.

E. PLACE AREAS UNDER NON-HUMAN CONTROL.

Areas that are controlled by non-humans should now be placed. Elves will prefer wooded places far from men, dwarves and goblins will prefer the mountains, and halflings will live on good farming land or gentle hills if they can. Many monsters will choose a "territory" to hunt in and defend, while orcs and similar creatures will raid and move around a great deal. Although non-human areas usually have no set boundaries, the DM may want to write the name of the most common or notable creature on the map in the areas they inhabit.



F. OUTLINE THE BASE TOWN.

The DM should first decide how large to make the town. Some general guidelines are:

Size	Population
Major City	15,000 +
Large Town	5000-14,999
Small Town	1000-4,999
Village	50-999

The base town should be large enough to support the services the players will need. These include:

Inns and townhouses where the players stay between adventures, where notices are posted, and where rumors are found.

Churches, shrines or temples for the clerical orders, including at least one NPC cleric powerful enough to cast a **raise dead** spell.

A Thieves' Guild for thief class characters that can provide information, markets for treasure, smuggling, spies, and hireling thieves — for a price.

Town militia to keep an eye on the town — and the players!

The DM should also decide who is running the town. Possibilities include a sheriff appointed by a baron, a town council with a charter, a powerful merchant prince, or even a high level NPC adventurer. NPC rulers should be at least name level, with appropriate bodyguards and magic.

G. FILL IN IMPORTANT DETAILS AND POINTS OF INTEREST.

The DM now finishes the small area map by creating local NPCs, local rumors, and points of interest. This could include anyone who might wish to hire adventurers and why they want to hire someone, whether the local officials take bribes, and how often the guard patrols a particular section of town, among other things. Minor townsfolk, officials, and other NPCs can be added, now also.

H. CREATE SPECIAL ENCOUNTER TABLES AND GENERAL LAIRS

There will probably be special areas of the wilderness map for which the standard encounter tables will not seem correct. The DM is encouraged to create his or her own tables for these places. Such a place might be a vast battlefield where undead are common, or a forest infested with orcs. Special encounter tables could reflect these unusual conditions. The DM is only limited by what he or she wants to include.

Finally, the DM may also want to prepare several typical caves or lairs but not locate them on the map. This way, should the players encounter a lair the DM has not had time to describe individually, he or she may use the predrawn cave or lair as needed. This is also useful for castle floor plans and ship decks. Likewise, if a random encounter occurs in the wilderness, the DM may want to draw a crude sketch map of the area for the players. This will help them understand what is in the area, what they see, and what they can do.